

International Students Guide

Introduction	2
Job & Internship Search	3
Internship Checklist	4
Resume	5
On-Campus Graduate Resume Sample	6
Internship & Job Graduate Resume Sample	7
Networking	8
LinkedIn	9
Interviewing	10



Introduction

As an international student, you have unique circumstances due to work authorization and employment eligibility. Navigating the job and internship search can be challenging due to factors such as work eligibility, legal complexities, cost of sponsorship, economic uncertainty, language barriers, cultural differences, and time pressure. However, international students also have their own strengths and often shine in areas such as intercultural fluency, technical competency, resilience, initiative, and career management.

Before starting your job and internship search, be sure to:

1. Visit the [International Student and Scholar Services \(ISSS\) website](#) and meet with an [ISSS advisor](#) to learn about employment eligibility.
2. Review our [career guides](#), which cover common topics such as job & internship search, networking, resumes, cover letters, and interviewing.

This guide provides additional guidance for international students.

Job & Internship Search

How to Find Jobs & Internships

Start by reviewing the [Job & Internship Search Guide](#). Start your search for on-campus jobs, internships, and full-time jobs with [SJSU Handshake](#) as early as possible. Be sure to update your [work authorization](#) on SJSU Handshake to accurately reflect your status. On the *Jobs* tab, select *Filter*, then select the *Work authorization options* (*CPT*, *OPT*, or *US visa sponsorship*) that apply to you.

On-Campus Jobs: Besides SJSU Handshake, you can also find on-campus jobs in the [Build Experience Guide](#). Keep in mind that there are more students seeking on-campus work than there are jobs available, and some positions have over 100 applicants. Here are some tips to be competitive:

- Tailor your resume to the job by including the job title in your objective. Focus on transferable skills, specifically customer service, communication, and teamwork, rather than technical skills and experience, unless you are applying for a technical on-campus job.
- See the [on-campus graduate resume sample](#).

Internships and Jobs: Check the [SJSU Handshake](#) calendar for upcoming employer events and job fairs. Be sure to check which majors, class years, and level (undergraduate vs. graduate) the employer is looking for. Below are additional resources to check out:

- [MyVisaJobs](#): H1B work visa database
- [US Department of Labor Report](#): Top employers and occupations with labor certifications

Tips to Be a Competitive Applicant

- **Consider culture fit when looking at companies.** Culture fit can be a crucial factor in the hiring process. Employees who match the company's culture tend to perform better, have increased job satisfaction, and higher retention rates. Think about how comfortable you would be in the work environment and whether your beliefs, values, and needs match that of the company.
- **Strengthen your English language skills.** Communication, both verbal and written, is one of the top skills employers are looking for. Get help with writing at the [SJSU Writing Center](#).
- **Build experience outside of academics.** Get involved in student organizations, volunteer at a non-profit, or compete in hackathons and challenges. See our [Build Experience Guide](#) for more ideas.
- **Highlight your strengths as an international student.** Showcase your ability to work in a diverse workplace, help your employer compete in a global economy, and tackle the unknown.

Internship Checklist

Use this checklist as a guide to securing an internship and the required Curricular Practical Training (CPT) employment authorization.



Step 1 Learn about CPT

Review the [CPT Tutorial](#) and [Frequently Asked Questions](#) created by the ISSS office. Follow the step-by-step guidance of the [CPT Application Process](#). Meet with an [ISSS advisor](#) for more specific questions. Bookmark [CPT Application Period Deadlines](#).



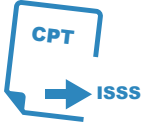
Step 2 Consult with an Academic/Faculty Advisor

You must enroll in an internship or self-study course in order to apply for CPT. Consult with your academic department to confirm if this course is offered.



Step 3 Secure Job Offer

Start your job search early in the semester before your CPT. Create an internship search plan using SJSU Handshake and other job boards, considering both paid and unpaid opportunities. Attend [career workshops](#) to improve skills like *resume writing*, *LinkedIn profile optimization*, *interview techniques*, and *networking*. Check the [Career Fairs and Events page](#) for networking and employer connection events (job fairs, info sessions, etc.) For further support, visit [drop-in career counseling](#), [schedule an appointment with a counselor](#), or use [online resources](#).



Step 4 Submit CPT Documents to ISSS

Submit a CPT application along with an internship offer letter to ISSS in order to request work authorization. ISSS takes 1-15 business days to process the work authorization document (a new Form I-20 for CPT).



Step 5 Pick Up I-20

Once your CPT I-20 is issued, you will receive an email to pick up the document at the ISSS office. The second page of the I-20 will show your work authorization information. Do NOT start working until you receive an I-20 with CPT authorization.



Step 6 Apply for a Social Security Number (SSN)

If you do not already have a social security number, you will need to apply for one after receiving your CPT I-20. Instructions on how to do this will be provided by the ISSS office.



Step 7 Start Internships and Share Success Stories

Share your internship success story. Contact careerhelp@sjsu.edu to schedule a time to discuss.

Resume

Start by reviewing our [Resume and Cover Letter Guide](#). Note key differences between a US resume and a resume in another country:

- A US resume is a one-to two-page summary that highlights relevant skills and experience based on the job description. Resumes are different from CVs, which are used more often internationally. A CV is longer and is a static document that includes an extensive history of your education and experience. In the US, CVs are typically only used for research or academic positions.
- Do not include personal information such as age, gender, marital status, ethnicity, or immigration status. Also do not include a photo or test scores (such as TOEFL).

Here are some top tips to making your resume stand out:

- **Check for spelling and grammar mistakes.** You can get help with writing at the [SJSU Writing Center](#).
- **Keep your resume to 1-2 pages.** Do not try to squeeze as much information in as possible, as this makes it difficult for the recruiter to scan. If you have additional experience that does not fit, include it on your LinkedIn profile.
- **Describe your accomplishments.** Replace passive phrases such as “responsible for” with strong action verbs, like “led,” “managed,” and “collaborated.” Quantify your resumes to show the impact of your work.
- **Include links to your LinkedIn, website, and GitHub account if you have one.** Use these sites to showcase examples of projects and proof of your work.
- **Demonstrate both technical skills and transferable skills** such as communication, teamwork, problem solving, and leadership.
- **Don’t focus on just academics.** Include experiences outside the classroom such as involvement in student organizations or volunteer work.
- **Provide a frame of reference for experience outside of the US.** For example, “interned at the #3 fastest growing company in India.”

On-Campus Graduate Resume Sample

IM A. SPARTAN

San Jose, CA | 408-456-7890 | imaspartan@gmail.com | linkedin.com/in/imaspartan

OBJECTIVE:

To utilize my strong leadership and organizational skills as a Front Desk Student Assistant Job at the SJSU Career Center

EDUCATION

Master of Science (M.S.), Computer Engineering, San Jose State University, San Jose, CA May 20xx
Bachelor of Engineering (B.E.), Computer Science, University of Mumbai, India June 20xx

EXPERIENCE

Network Engineer Intern, Tata Consultancy Services, India March 20xx - June 20xx

- Collaborated with team of 4 engineers to create network protocols for the leading telecommunication group in India
- Utilized creative problem solving and critical thinking skills to troubleshoot various issues
- Presented final project to panel of 3 managers utilizing Powerpoint slidedeck and handouts

Marketing Team Lead, Computer Society, University of Mumbai, India January 20xx - September 20xx

- Led team of two students to develop marketing strategies based on in-depth research of student needs
- Re-designed website using HTML and Java to promote upcoming events
- Marketed events using posters on-campus and social media, leading to event participation of 20-100 students

Computer Science Tutor, Academic Tutoring Center, University of Mumbai September 20xx - December 20xx

- Taught students one-on-one and group settings to improve their C++ skills
- Helped student improve two grade levels over the course of a semester

AWARDS AND ACTIVITIES

Outstanding Achievement in Mathematics Award, Rotary International June 20xx

Event Organizer Volunteer, TechFest, University of Mumbai March 20xx

- Collaborated with team of 25 to organize campuswide event for over 250 participants
- Managed and ran two booths throughout the day

Team Captain, University of Mumbai Cricket Team January 20xx - January 20xx

RELEVANT SKILLS

Microsoft Word, Excel, Powerpoint, HTML, CSS, C++, Java

Internship/Job Graduate Resume Sample

IM A. SPARTAN

Mountain View, CA | 408-456-7890 | imaspartan@gmail.com | git.hub/imaspartan | linkedin.com/in/imaspartan

OBJECTIVE: To obtain an Electrical Engineer Internship at KLA Tencor

EDUCATION

M.S. in Electrical & Electronics Engineering, San Jose State University, San Jose, CA May 20xx

B.E. in Electronics Engineering, University of Mumbai, India June 20xx

SKILLS

Technical: Cadence Virtuoso, Cadence SigXplorer, MATLAB, Xilinx ISE, subversion, C, Python, Shell scripting, VHDL, Verilog-A, Oscilloscope, Multimeter, Spectrum Analyzer, Network Analyzer, Waveform Generator, Linux, Windows

EXPERIENCE

Junior Software Engineer, Indigo Technologies, Pune, India July 20xx - July 20xx

- Developed user interface application on NXP Libra, ST 5197 & Renesas SoC platforms
- Collaborated with the business analysts, quality assurance and content writer team to develop UI
- Implemented functionalities and features in channel zapper boxes
- Developed video streaming web applications on high end set top boxes
- Conducted demos of newly developed features for prospective clients

PROJECTS

Interface between microcontroller and DDR2 memory, SJSU Fall 20xx

- Prepared design guide for interfacing PowerQUICC II Pro Processor and Micron 1GB memory
- Performed signal integrity analysis using Cadence SigXplorer to successfully enhanced performance

Design & Characterization of a Polar Transmitter, SJSU Spring 20xx

- Utilized Verilog-A for designing digital controller
- Carefully selected the correct phase and amplifier gain for a given input
- Optimized the phase shifter using OCEAN programming

Matched Network Design for LNA, SJSU Spring 20xx

- Created impedance matching network and conducted analysis of circuit design
- Met strict global parameters using transmission lines
- Utilized scattered parameters, Smith Chart and impedance analysis

ACTIVITIES

Member, IEEE Student Chapter, SJSU September 20xx - Present

Networking

Start by reviewing the networking section in the [Job/Internship Search Guide](#). Here are some tips for networking:

- When first meeting someone, greet with “How are you?” or “How are you doing?”
- Prepare conversation starters for small talk such as:
 - **Student Events:** What major are you studying? What year are you?
 - **Industry Events:** What brought you to this event? What do you do?
 - **Conferences:** What session are you most excited about? Is this your first time attending this conference? How long have you been a part of this organization?
- Avoid controversial topics such as religion, politics and sex. Discussing salary should also be avoided.
- Understand [American Culture and Etiquette](#) and be mindful of cultural differences when interacting with others.
- Use every opportunity to network. Networking doesn’t have to happen at an event – it is simply connecting with people and can start with your peers, professors, and neighbors.

Here are some ways you can network with peers and industry professionals:

- Check out upcoming events at the [SJSU International House](#).
- Join the [International Circle](#)—a support group facilitated by the [SJSU Student Wellness Center](#). This is a safe space for international students to connect, share experiences, explore cultural differences, and navigate life in the U.S. together.
- Join [student organizations](#) on campus such as the [Global Student Network](#). Use the [Professional Associations Search](#) to search organizations by industry.
- Join the [San Jose State University Students \(International Students Group\)](#) on Facebook.
- Practice public speaking skills by joining [Toastmasters International](#)—there’s a club called [Downtown Speechmakers](#) within walking distance of campus.
- Search for industry or interest related events on [Eventbrite](#) and [Meetup](#).

Networking: LinkedIn

LinkedIn is a great tool for connecting with professionals in your industry. Here are some tips to make the most out of LinkedIn:

- Follow companies you are interested in to learn about current projects, product launches, and initiatives, as well as recruiters from companies you are interested in to get information on hiring opportunities.
- Join industry and interest related groups such as [International Students LinkedIn Group](#).
- If you completed your bachelor's degree outside of the United States, use LinkedIn to identify alumni from your university who are now employed in the US. Search for your university on LinkedIn and click *Alumni*. Then filter by *San Francisco Bay Area* under *Where they live* and your field of interest under *What they do* or your major under *What they studied*. Find someone with mutual connections currently working in your field and request to connect with them. Be sure to include a personal message about why you are connecting.

Savitribai Phule Pune University

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Home About Posts Jobs **Alumni**

2,835 alumni

Search alumni by title, keyword or company

San Francisco Bay Area Clear all

Start year End year

+ Add

India

-Chinchwad Area

What they do

2,835 | Engineering

780 | Information Technology

570 | Business Development

What they are skilled at

1,572 | Java

1,387 | Python (Programmi

1,286 | C++

Interviewing

To prepare for an interview with an employer in the US, review our [Interviewing Guide](#). Here are additional tips for acing the US interview:

- Arrive at least 10-15 minutes early to the interview.
- Dress professionally but appropriate for the company culture. As a general rule, dress a step above what employees would typically wear to a work day.
- Treat everyone you come in contact with with courtesy and respect.
- Be aware of your non-verbal communication. When you first meet the interviewer, give a firm handshake. During the interview, maintain eye contact and show enthusiasm through your tone of voice and facial expressions. Maintain professionalism by having good posture. Respect personal space by keeping about 30-36 inches between you and the interviewer.
- Take an active role in the interview. Be prepared to show why you are the best candidate for the position, elaborate on your responses, and ask questions of the interviewer. This may be different than the interview culture in other countries, where promoting your own accomplishments is discouraged and taking a passive role is expected.

For more tips on interviewing, see this article [Interviewing Across Cultures](#) by Pamela Leri, Guest Columnist for GoinGlobal.